



Salathe Wall 5.13b or 5.9 C2

El Capitan

Yosemite Valley, California USA

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TRIP REPORT

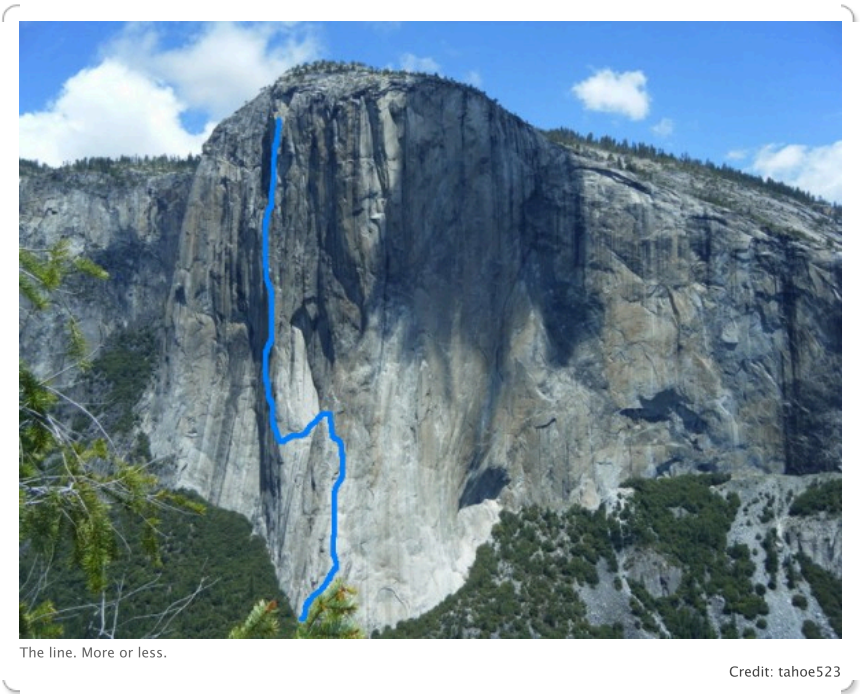
A Laywoman's Account of a Not Too Soggy Siege on the Salathe with Some Spaniards

by [tahoe523](#)

Wednesday June 15, 2011 2:36am

I throw open the door and blow chunks. No time to waste. I don't even bother getting out of the car.

See here, I'm a 9 to 5 slave monkey. I don't have endless days to leisurely choose my non-cubical adventures. Hell or high water, I was going to get to Heart Ledges that night. Two dry heave and rally sessions later, I'm at El Cap Bridge. I pray that the bad taco truck fiasco of 2011 is over, throw on the harness and start running toward the captain.



My friends and I made it as far as the alcove last week and barely survived the storm that blew through the valley. Stymied by the downpour of water on the route, the four of us were forced to come down after playing human tetris in a double portaledge for 36 hours. I won't lament over our first world problems. Plus, we had whiskey. And as a wise fortune cookie once said, things can always be worse.

Trip Reports

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May 29, 2019; 12:28pm
- Coonyard Pinnacle 50 Years Later

May 29, 2019; 12:24pm
- Great Pumpkin with Mr Kamps and McClinsky-1971

May 29, 2019; 12:02pm



Credit: Tom Evans

The weather finally decided to play nice; haunted by prior defeat, it was time to finish what we had started. I had to be back in SF 9am Monday. My boss wasn't going to accept a "sorry, stuck on El Cap" text message.

I jug like a lunatic up to Lung Ledge with a whole roasted chicken in tow. I am met with great enthusiasm. The plan was for me to jump on the hollow flake in the dark so as to not burn precious day light hours the next day grunting up the thing. However, after all the barfing down below and all the jugging up above, I wasn't in the best condition to fight with the rock. Midnight. Bellies full. We snooze.

Pitch 14: I flashed this bad boy the first go around and told my proud tale [here](#). The weekend warrior clock was tick tocking. No time to waste. Knowing the exact width of the cavity I returned with some DIY A0 ammunition.

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Other Routes on El Capitan



The Nose, 5.14a or 5.9 C2
El Capitan

The Nose—the best rock climb in the world!



Freerider, 5.12D
El Capitan

The Salathé Wall ascends the most natural line up El Cap.



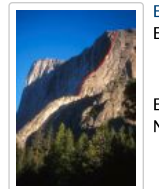
Zodiac, A2 5.7
El Capitan

1800' of fantastic climbing.



Lurking Fear, C2F 5.7
El Capitan

Lurking Fear is route number 1.



East Buttress, 5.10b
El Capitan

East Buttress with top of The Nose on left.

[More routes on El Capitan](#)



A Black Diamond #6 Camalot = \$60. A #7? \$63.25

Credit: tahoe523



Perfect yellow alien placement at the "crux" of the Hollow Flake

Credit: tahoe523

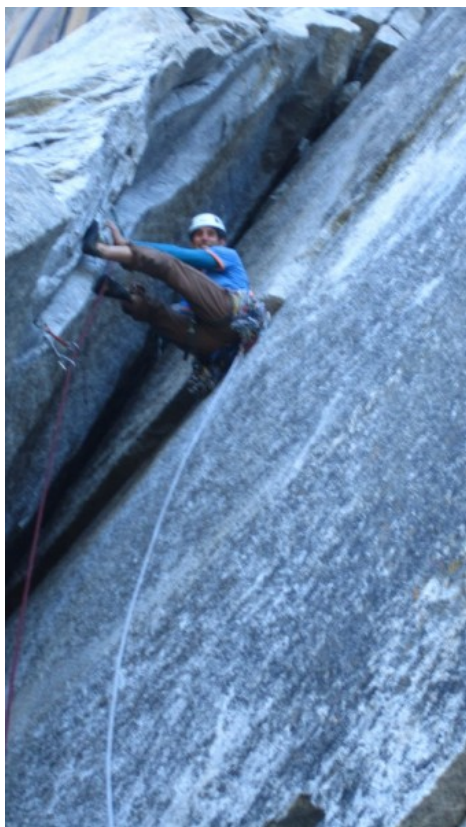
Take the left knee pad and put it on the right arm. Your elbow will thank you.



The Hollow Flake

Credit: tahoe523

Pitch 15: Fun! But careful, somewhere a quarter up the way is a loose block on the edge.



Credit: tahoe523

As I belayed, we scope out a SIAD team running toward us. I watched them dance up the HF in a matter of minutes. I stood there dumbfounded, in awe and we let them pass.

So far I've scratched off 27 of the 100 things I want to accomplish before I die. And while this might

come as a surprise to you, climbing The Ear twice is not one of them. My partners have more pride than me because they wouldn't ask the other team the million dollar question. Plus, as agreed, it was my lead. With shame, I piped up and asked her if she could fix our rope while we waited for them to pass and charge ahead. It wasn't my proudest moment, but the timing was right and the opportunity lent itself. In rebuttal, if I hadn't ever lead the thing, there was no way any of us would have juggled a pitch we hadn't climbed. I survived it once. I had my heart set on getting to El Cap Spire in daylight. She graciously accepted (heaps of appreciation if you're out there reading this). I humbly juggled. My partners were elated. Neither wanted to clean that pitch again.

Take it from someone who isn't a hardman. If you aren't either, bring a #4 and #5. Back clean the 4 once you get the 5 in place because your partner will thank you for not having to squeeze back there to clean it and you can protect the exit with the 4, too. But before you get there, yes, you will have to free climb... dun dun dun... 5.8.



view from within the ear

Credit: tahoe523

Sling your stuff long and back clean some of the earlier pro or suffer the wrath of some heinous, ball sucking, rope drag (the pitch wanders like a backwards question mark). There's also a good bolt out on the face to clip before a really cool layback move to the anchor.

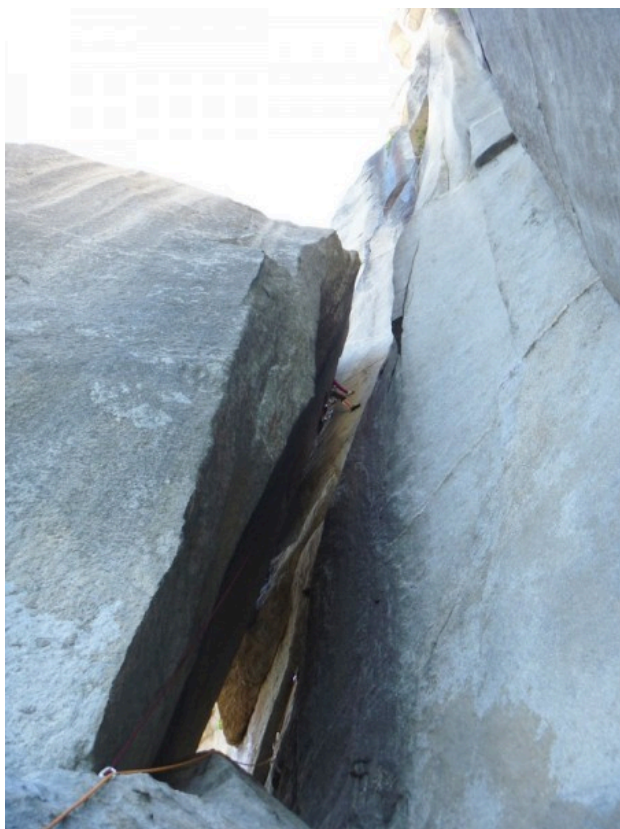


Above the ear pitch.

Credit: Tom Evans

All in all, G-rated and protectable, but you can go with the trademark Donini, it's just a chimney and you can't fall out of it thesis. I only climb 5.10. That's my beta and I'm sticking to it.

Enough ear talk! Moving right along. We make it back to the alcove and before I let the PTSD sink in, I chimney my way up the airy cavity to El Cap Spire.



Credit: tahoe523

AMAZING! I'm in heaven! Except I don't have wings. Can't fly. Also, not surrounded by nice, dead people.



Jugging up to the spire

Credit: tahoe523

We've all seen the historical photo of Royal Robbins on ECS.



Credit: Tom Frost

Ours is only slightly less classic.



Splayed out on El Cap Spire

Credit: tahoe523

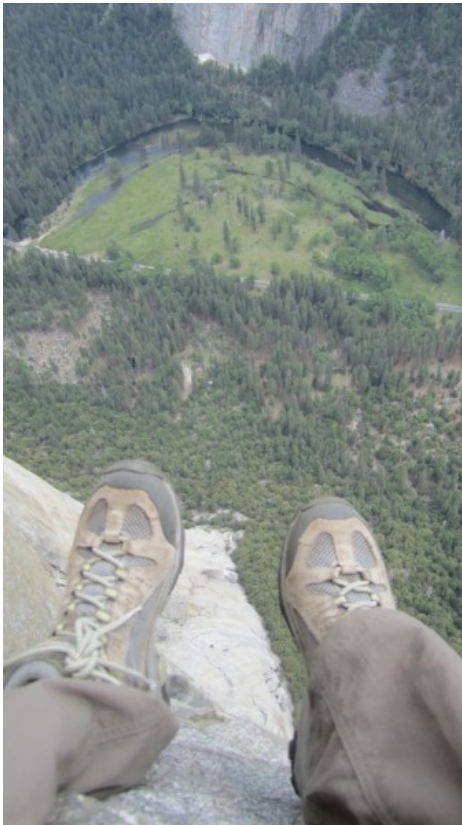
We feast and relish in the glory of our great bivy site, but know that we've got a long day ahead of us tomorrow if we were going to make it to long ledge. Bellies full. We snoozed, night two, in our spacious abode.

I can confidently say that Yoga has given me the strength of 100 men. Skinny, metrosexual, crunchy Bay Area vegan men, but still. While my partners linked like crazy (P21+22, P24+25, P27+28, P29-31 with a 70m rope), I was a juggling and hauling MACHINE.



The very moist sewer pitch 24

Credit: tahoe523



View from Sous Le Toit

Credit: tahoe523



Pitch 27 leading up to the roof. Ha. Tick marks. Unless I'm anatomically modified with robot parts, I will never in this lifetime free 5.12d, but it's cool to see signs that people without robot parts or pro sponsorships doing so. Crazy.

Credit: tahoe523



juggling the headwall

Credit: tahoe523

With plenty of daylight left we setup camp on Long Ledge, which, as its name would suggest, is indeed very long and almost more fun to bivy on than El Cap Spire.



the silhouette of my partner on long ledge

Credit: tahoe523

Waking up and definitely not disappointed with reality.



view from Long Ledge

Credit: tahoe523



With only a few pitches left to the top, we slept in.

Credit: tahoe523



clearly it still wasn't long enough for everyone. grigri, to you, we salute

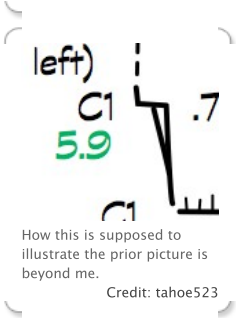
Credit: tahoe523

Last real pitch before the top is yet another gaping canal ready to spit you out. The topo doesn't have a name for this pitch. I shall call it the angry vagina.



the last squeeze

Credit: tahoe523





me 1, angry vagina 0

Credit: tahoe523

Same as the ear, if you like your partner, back clean the red #1 you can place before you squirm down and out. A big green 6 protects the squeeze. The hold out left isn't that blind. I tried to link 33 and 34 but I placed way too much gear in the pitch below and the rope drag was unbearable. I ended up linking 34 and 35.



A snowy summit view in June. Love it.

Credit: tahoe523

After a three day journey of a few thousand feet, we finally make it to the top!



SUMMIT!

Credit: tahoe523

A fairly quick jaunt back down to the bridge, I come to find in horror that my car is missing. Brain, what part of 'don't loan out your car to a complete stranger while climbing' do you not understand? I was back on the ground and yet epic'ing. Tom offered us beer. Problem solved. I was drunk and happy.

Hours later I get my car out of the NPS impound. Too tired to drive back to SF just yet, I crash in the International House of Euros tent. 2am I drag my half dead carcass across the parking lot and drive like a lunatic back to the bay area. I pull up to Mission Cliffs and shower in the fetal position.

9am I am in the office wearing dress pants to cover up the 17 bruises I had acquired on this excellent adventure. I just climbed El Cap. Psyched! 'Til next weekend. On deck: Lurking Fear.

Cubical monkey, over n out.

Trip Report Views: 11,166



tahoe523

About the Author

Shino Jomoto is a trad climber from Station Wagon, USA. She can finally say that she has freed all but 264 moves on El Capitan.

Comments

Mighty Hiker

climber
Outside the Asylum

Thank you! A marvellous report!

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:02am PT



roy

Social climber
NZ -> SB, CA ->
Zurich

Great report and lots of fun.

Cheers, Roy

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:18am PT



mcreel

climber
Barcelona

Nice TR, very entertaining. What happened to El Cap Spire, an earthquake rotated it sometime since RR's ascent?

Jun 15, 2011 - 04:31am PT



nutjob

Sport climber
Almost to
Hollywood, Baby!

OUTSTANDING

Jun 15, 2011 - 04:42am PT



Nice one!

Jun 15, 2011 - 07:33am PT

telemon01Trad climber
Montana**JohnnyG**

climber

Angry vagina! HA hahahahah!

this is the best trip report ever

Jun 15, 2011 - 08:53am PT

**Jan**Mountain climber
Colorado & Nepal

Great photos, fun trip report!

It's also a wonderful example of how climbing has changed over the years.

I hope someone puts it into an El Cap anthology some day.

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:51pm PT

**neversummer**climber
30 mins. from
suicide USA

good job... looks like a blast.

Jun 15, 2011 - 10:38am PT

**couchmaster**

climber

LOL, love the jaunty writing, good stuff! Congrats on the fine send and thanks for sharing it.
What was the story with the car? The NPS hates imports or something now? 2 family's of bears
moved into it and mama bear got her ass stuck in the opening? ?

Jun 15, 2011 - 11:45am PT

**stilltrying**Trad climber
washington indiana

Awesome !!!!

Jun 15, 2011 - 11:46am PT

**Hoser**climber
Vancouver,Rome

very well written!

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:04pm PT

**b.caskey**climber
Tahoe, NV

oh do i know the story of that car and its pilot! we met your craigsist rideshare buddy at the
curry bar on his birthday. 'interesting' dude. he was almost arrested that night simply for being
an ass to some rangers on the housekeeping bridge.

don't know what story you got about your car, but he got a DUI in the park sometime the next
day/night - driving in the bus only area behing the grocery! i'm sure you know as you got your
car back. real solid guy.

not jealous one bit that you had to be trapped in a box with that guy from SF to Yo. he loved to
hear the sound of his own voice.

anywhos, nice work on the salathe! congrats and great write up!

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:35pm PT

**msiddens**

Trad climber

what a rad TR. You rock and thanks!

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:35pm PT

**SteveW**Trad climber
The state of
confusion

Better than FABULOUS!!!!!!!

AWESOME!!!!

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:45pm PT

**Edge**

Trad climber

Awesome write up and pics. Congrats!

Jun 15, 2011 - 12:49pm PT

**murcy**Gym climber
sanfrancisco

Jun 15, 2011 - 01:18pm PT
Was waiting for this and scrutinizing Tom's reports. Awesome TR and great accomplishment!
Love the modded cam.

**Mungeclimber**Trad climber
Nothing creative to
say

Jun 15, 2011 - 01:51pm PT
hahaha, great descriptors of the experience. Yoga strength cracked me up.

**Jaybro**Social climber
Wolf City, Wyoming

Jun 15, 2011 - 01:56pm PT
Now *That's* a trip report! Congrats on the climb and esp the presentation!

Angry Vagina! Hahaha! G.e.t.s.!

**BMcC**Trad climber
Livermore

Jun 15, 2011 - 02:06pm PT
Great pics and TR! and so very funny, too!

**Doug Robinson**Trad climber
Santa Cruz

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:08pm PT
Totally cool, with attitude.
You're a seriously good -- no, make that off-the-wall goofball good -- writer.

Can't wait for your next adventure.

**Clint Cummins**Trad climber
SF Bay area, CA

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:30pm PT
The best!
Thanks for sharing.

And may I humbly offer this tweaked version of the Hollow Flake shot, so that people don't get
the impression that it's more heinous than it already is....

**Reilly**Mountain climber
The Other
Monrovia- CA

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:27pm PT
A most excellent adventure most excellently related. Thanks!

**aguacaliente**

climber

Jun 15, 2011 - 03:36pm PT
WINNING !

**tahoe523**Trad climber
Station Wagon, USA

Jun 15, 2011 - 11:30pm PT
Author's Reply
I wasn't sure whether the projectile vomiting was from listening to him ramble on for three
hours about how amazing he was or from the taquitos. A bit of both I'm thinking. Despite his
bravado, he seemed like a pretty harmless guy, so I let him borrow my car.

As you can imagine, upon discovering that my car was no where to be found, I was filled with
visceral rage. Lucky for me, the effects of cheap alcohol prevailed. He never told me about a DUI.
He just wanked on about how much park services suck without any merit. My car was towed
because the idiot parked my car in a red zone and kept drugs in the backseat. Awesome!
Thanks, Dude!

Anyhoots, I wasn't going to let him or the impound detract from my awesome trip up the
captain. We had a blast; never hungry, never thirsty and most importantly, never COLD. Our only
regret was, you know, not freeing 5.13c. And yes, Clint(!), you have it angled accurately. :) I
promise I didn't photoshop the perspective, but I'm sure my friends were trying to make it look
scary to psyche out their offwidth hating peeps back in Europe.

And as far as pitch 34 goes, if anyone here is friends with Chris McNamara or Chris Van Leuven,
please tell them that they should consider editing the topo in the 4th edition with this more
accurate depiction of that last squeeze-fest.

Jun 15, 2011 - 11:51pm PT
F*n brilliant! Tell us where your cube is so we can get you fired and read more trip reports!

**Rhodo-Router**Gym climber
sawatch choss**Fritz**Social climber
Choss Creek, ID

I love your writing! Thanks for sharing the climb and photos!

Jun 15, 2011 - 11:59pm PT

**Gagner**climber
Boulder

Awesome

WOO HOO!!

Paul

Jun 16, 2011 - 12:26am PT

**Daphne**Trad climber
Northern California

What an excellent report excellently written. Thanks so much for posting this. You rock!

Jun 16, 2011 - 12:50am PT

**10b4me**Social climber
Lida Junctionfor being a 9 to 5er, seems like you are pretty hardcore,
thanks for the tr. I liked your Astroman tr too

Jun 16, 2011 - 01:20am PT

**Cain J Waters**Mountain climber
Ithaca, NYThe TR I was looking for that did not disappoint! Looking casual and all smiles. Really enjoyed
the photos and writing style. Bravo, team! -CW

Jun 16, 2011 - 10:18am PT

**Jay Wood**Trad climber
Land of God-less
fools

Awesome, thanks.

I'm slightly less gripped at the thought of that wideness now.

Jun 16, 2011 - 04:06pm PT

**J. Werlin**Social climber
Cedaredge, CO

Awesome! Many thanks.

Jun 16, 2011 - 04:16pm PT

**golsen**Social climber
kennewick, wa

Flat out AWESOME!

Thanks and good job!

Jun 16, 2011 - 04:51pm PT

**BrianH**Trad climber
santa fe

I want to party with you. Even more, I want to climb with you!

Jun 17, 2011 - 06:12pm PT

**karodrinker**Trad climber
San Jose, CASweet! We all salute your radness. Nice motivation! Whoop whoop!
And quit with the laywoman crap as your obviously not.

Jun 17, 2011 - 06:50pm PT

Jun 17, 2011 - 08:18pm PT

**Dirka**Trad climber
Hustle City

Killar!

**Kalimon**Social climber
Ridgway, CO

Wow! Excellent effort and great example for the rest of us working class inmates.

Jun 17, 2011 - 08:54pm PT

**crunch**Social climber
COGreat read! And nice photos. Brings back fond memories of the magnificent architecture of the Salathe Wall; The Spire, Hollow Flake, and the Ear, and most of all the amazing Long Ledge bivouac ledge.
Thanks

Jun 18, 2011 - 05:13pm PT

**slidingmike**climber
CA

Thank you for the great TR -- it's inspiring!

Jun 18, 2011 - 05:56pm PT

**drljefe**climber
El Presidio San
Augustin del Tucson

All time.

Jun 18, 2011 - 06:14pm PT

**Karl Baba**Trad climber
Yosemite, Ca

Super Great!

Jun 18, 2011 - 06:32pm PT

**Roger Breedlove**climber
Cleveland Heights,
Ohio

Love your trip reports. Great climb made greater by good storytelling.

Jun 20, 2011 - 05:08pm PT

How about a photo of your cubical, just for the sake of perspective.

**Blue Devil**Mountain climber
Virginia countryside

Best title ever! Who knew while being the juggin machine you'd also win best stacked? That CamNut beats my last best double Hex for damn sure. You should go into business.

Jun 20, 2011 - 05:31pm PT

What a trip. Thanks and see you around In Station Wagon.
BD**Gane**Ice climber
State of Confusion

A great write about a great feat!

Jun 22, 2011 - 11:02am PT

**sclausen**Trad climber
Foster City, CA

Absolutely brilliant ...

Jun 23, 2011 - 02:33pm PT

**zeta**Trad climber
Portland, OR

awesome trip report! it had me laughing and ancy to get back to Yosemite...looking forward to your next TR

Jun 23, 2011 - 06:45pm PT

**johntp**Trad climber
Punter, Little Rock

Sweet! Missed this until now. Freaking hilarious! Thanks

Jun 23, 2011 - 07:27pm PT

**JLP**Social climber
The internet

The angry vagina as you call it is a pretty easy lie-back. There are good feet out there. You don't need to squeeze up that thing. Just step out to the left, get the feet, then drop back into a pretty secure lie-back. You're on TR for the slightly insecure drop-out move that gets you started. It's actually a pretty cool pitch.

Jun 23, 2011 - 07:45pm PT

**tahoe523**Trad climber
Station Wagon, USA

Author's Reply

Well, like they say, there's more than one way to f*ck a woman scorned.

Jun 24, 2011 - 02:29pm PT

In other news, I can't believe Roger Breedlove read my TR. That made my day. Hi, Roger.

Thanks for taking the time to read about our little adventure. I have received one too many 'post another picture of you climbing on rocks and I will forever ban you from my facebook newsfeed' threats, so it's nice to know that I can share pictures of rocks with you all, whom I've never met, this colorful peanut gallery that is Supertopo.

**russellg**Sport climber
Malibu, CA

Great trip report! Might have to pick your brain for more beta at some point!

Jun 30, 2011 - 01:15pm PT

**Paulina**Trad climber
Seattle, WA

Love your trip reports! And the suggested topo mod.

Jun 30, 2011 - 01:30pm PT

**CathC**Social climber
Wyoming

Loved this story !! Congrats !!

Jun 30, 2011 - 01:44pm PT

**Lace**climber
Seattle, WA

awesome.. gets me re-excited

Jun 30, 2011 - 03:33pm PT

**canoeper**

climber

I admire the courage of these fine climbers, it takes me back to the old days of Squamish Climbing, I wish I could still find this courage. So I took up another sport!! Long distance ocean canoe journeys!! Great report With admiration Chris G. Cooper
<http://www.spiritdancercanoejourneys.ca>

Jul 2, 2011 - 02:56pm PT

**Russ Aulds**Trad climber
Delano, TN

GOOD STUFF!!!! :)

Jul 3, 2011 - 09:14am PT

**mooser**Trad climber
seattle

I think this is my favorite TR to date. Fantastic! And the set-up for the picture sequence on the Spire was HI-Larious! Thanks for the great start to my day.

Jul 3, 2011 - 09:41am PT

**rockgobbler**

Big Wall climber

Awesome pics and great account. Nice one! Can't wait to try it myself....

Jul 3, 2011 - 09:46am PT

London, UK

**Doug Buchanan**Mountain climber
Fairbanks Alaska

Jolly good climb and write up.

Keep writing, climbing and thinking that fast.

Doug

Jul 3, 2011 – 06:36pm PT

**Gal**Trad climber
going big air to
fakie

Fantastic! I like that you cut it close for getting back in time for work--this is what I would do too! After all--the weekends are the time to get up early and do fun work--the cubicle work week is the time to rest and sleep in ;-)

Thanks so much!

Jul 3, 2011 – 07:17pm PT

**Clint Cummins**Trad climber
SF Bay area, CA

Randomly noticed this photo from your climb on facebook:

<http://www.facebook.com/photo.php?fbid=211307392248310&set=a.155810587797991.27582.100001071513920&type=1&theater>
but he has it mislabeled as the Nose! :-)

Jul 18, 2011 – 04:41pm PT

**Roxy**Trad climber
CA Central Coast

awesome adventure and pics!

love the tom robbins--esque title

Nov 8, 2011 – 10:51pm PT

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